VIBE WITH JUDEO · CASE FILES

THE TARAIA OBJECT

AMELIA EARHART · 1937 → 2026

STATUS: LAGOON RULED OUT · SEARCH GOES ON



FREE FIELD EDITION · 11 PAGES
FACTS CHECKED TO 21 OCT 2026
EVERY CLAIM GRADED AND SOURCED

Cover: Nikumaroro atoll from space. NASA Earth Observatory image by Joshua Stevens, using Landsat data from the US Geological Survey (public domain). NASA's own labels.

THE CASE IN 60 SECONDS

A SHAPE IN A LAGOON

On 2 July 1937 Amelia Earhart and her navigator Fred Noonan vanished on the Lae-to-Howland leg of a flight around the world. The official finding: they ran out of fuel and went down at sea near Howland Island. A rival theory says they landed on Nikumaroro, an uninhabited atoll about 400 miles away, and died there as castaways. In 2020 a dark shape in satellite images of Nikumaroro's lagoon, the “Taraia Object”, looked to some like the wreck of her plane. In October 2026 a 17-person expedition went to look. Its answer: probably a pile of large trees.

89 yrs
MISSING, JUL 1937 → OCT 2026

~400 mi
NIKUMARORO TO HOWLAND (350 NM)

7 days
NEAR THE ISLAND IN 2026, 4 OF THEM ASHORE

CASE CARD

ITEM	RECORD	GRADE
Who	Amelia Earhart, 39, and navigator Fred Noonan, 44	VERIFIED
Lost	2 Jul 1937, on the Lae (New Guinea) → Howland Island leg, about 2,556 statute miles	VERIFIED
Last message logged	“We are on the line 157 337…”, logged by the Coast Guard cutter *Itasca*. The text is on the log; the exact time (around 8:43 a.m.) is disputed	VERIFIED CONFLICT
The plane	Lockheed Electra 10E, aluminium-skinned; 38 ft 7 in long, 55 ft wingspan. Only 15 were built	VERIFIED
Official finding	Out of fuel, down at sea near Howland. Declared dead in absentia on 5 Jan 1939	VERIFIED
The object	A dark shape on the lagoon floor by the Taraia Peninsula, spotted in 2020 by US Navy veteran Michael Ashmore on Apple Maps	VERIFIED
Who looked (2026)	Archaeological Legacy Institute (ALI), which led, with Purdue Research Foundation and Purdue University	VERIFIED
Where	Nikumaroro, Phoenix Islands, Kiribati. Part of the Phoenix Islands Protected Area	VERIFIED

THE 2026 ANSWER (AS OF 21 OCT 2026)

Announced on 19 October 2026, local time: the expedition “found no conclusive evidence” of the Electra. The object was “likely a collection of large trees” on the peninsula's sandspit; its shine came from a carbonate crust, not metal. A steel tube about 30 inches long was recovered and had not been identified. Purdue says the search will go on.

How to read the grades. VERIFIED a primary source (Purdue, ALI, NARA, TIGHAR on its own work) or several independent outlets agree. ATTRIBUTED one outlet, or a party with a stake; we say who. CONFLICT credible sources disagree; we show both. UNVERIFIED could not be traced to a reliable source; we don't state it as fact. OUR CALCULATION our arithmetic from a cited input.

TIMELINE

1937 TO 2026

THE FLIGHT

1936
The Purdue Research Foundation's Amelia Earhart Fund for Aeronautical Research raises about $50,000 and finances the Electra she calls her “Flying Laboratory”. VERIFIED Accounts of how much went on the plane vary ($40,000 to $80,000). CONFLICT

2 JUL 1937
Earhart and Noonan vanish between Lae and Howland. The *Itasca* logs a last message around 8:43 a.m.: “We are on the line 157 337”. VERIFIED

2–18 JUL 1937
Navy and Coast Guard search. The Navy says it covered more than 250,000 square miles; that is an area figure, not proof every part was seen. ATTRIBUTED

OCT 1937
Colonial officer Eric Bevington photographs something on the reef near the 1929 wreck of the SS *Norwich City*. TIGHAR's analyst later called it consistent with Electra landing gear; nothing was ever found there. CONFLICT

1 DEC 1938
A New Zealand survey photographs the whole atoll from the air. VERIFIED ALI says two frames show what is likely the object. ATTRIBUTED I-Kiribati settlers arrive that month and stay until 1963. VERIFIED

5 JAN 1939
Earhart is declared dead in absentia. VERIFIED

THE ISLAND CLUES

1940–41
Colonists find a skull. Administrator Gerald Gallagher finds more bones, part of a shoe, a bottle and a sextant box (radio report, 23 Sep 1940). In Fiji, Dr D. W. Hoodless measures 13 bones and judges them probably male. The bones are later lost. VERIFIED

1988–89
TIGHAR starts its Earhart Project and makes its first Nikumaroro trip: more than a dozen expeditions over 30-plus years follow. VERIFIED

2018
A study of Hoodless's measurements says they are closer to Earhart than to 99% of a 2,776-person reference sample. VERIFIED Its meaning is disputed (see page 7). CONFLICT The sextant box is traced to a 1939 US Navy survey, so it is not Earhart evidence. VERIFIED

AUG 2019
Robert Ballard searches the deep water off Nikumaroro. No plane. VERIFIED

THE TARAIA OBJECT

2015 → 2020
ALI says the shape first shows in satellite imagery on 27 Apr 2015, a month after Cyclone Pam. ATTRIBUTED Michael Ashmore spots it on Apple Maps in 2020. VERIFIED He now labels his image “Debunked”. ATTRIBUTED

JUL 2025 → JUL 2026
The expedition is announced on 2 Jul 2025, postponed that autumn, then relaunched on 24 Jul 2026 after Kiribati's cabinet approves it. VERIFIED

EARLY OCT 2026
The team sails from Tarawa: about 830 nautical miles, five days at sea. (Purdue's releases give 6 and 7 Oct for the departure.) CONFLICT

12–14 OCT 2026
Arrives after dark on 12 Oct; ashore on the 13th; surveys the lagoon with a magnetometer and side-scan sonar on the 14th. Then weather keeps the team on the ship three days in a row, and the trip is extended. VERIFIED

19 OCT 2026
Result (local time): not the plane; likely a collection of large trees. A 30-inch steel tube is recovered, unidentified. Purdue pledges to keep searching. VERIFIED

THE MAPS

HOWLAND, NIKUMARORO, TARAIA



The last leg and the line of position. Earhart's final logged message gave a line (157°/337°) through Howland, not a point; the castaway theory says they followed it south-south-east to Nikumaroro. Basemap: NASA Blue Marble shaded relief and bathymetry (public domain); places plotted by us. The dashed leg is the planned route, not a track.



Nikumaroro (2014). NASA Earth Observatory image by Joshua Stevens, using Landsat data from the US Geological Survey (public domain); NASA's labels ("Seven Site", scale, north). Our additions: the Taraia Peninsula on the lagoon's north side, where the object was seen, is **approximate**: we placed it from published descriptions, and the team has not published coordinates. Tatiman Passage is the natural opening on the west side. The Seven Site is where TIGHAR places the 1940 bones discovery.

The atoll. About 7–7.5 km long and 2–2.5 km wide, around a shallow lagoon that TIGHAR says averages no more than about 5 m deep. VERIFIED ATTRIBUTED Uninhabited today; settlers lived here from 1938 to 1963. VERIFIED

The theory the team tested. The plane landed on the reef flat, floated off on the tide, lost its wings and engines in the surf, and the fuselage drifted through Tatiman Passage and sank near Taraia. That is ALI's hypothesis, not an established fact. ATTRIBUTED

THE 2026 EXPEDITION

HOW TO IDENTIFY A PLANE YOU CAN'T SEE

17
PEOPLE IN THE TEAM, PLUS A SHIP'S CREW OF 17

830 nm
TARAWA TO NIKUMARORO, FIVE DAYS AT SEA

~$900K
ALI'S ANTICIPATED BUDGET, NOT A FINAL COST

The Taraia Object Expedition was led by the Archaeological Legacy Institute of Eugene, Oregon, under its founder Richard "Rick" Pettigrew, with Purdue Research Foundation and Purdue University; Purdue's team lead was its general counsel, Steve Schultz. Maritime archaeologists came from RECON Offshore. Three Kiribati representatives joined at Tarawa, and the team sailed on the *Marin Mainiku*, a Kiribati landing craft. VERIFIED The plan was to identify the object only: nothing was to be removed on this trip, and any removal would need Kiribati's approval. VERIFIED

THE METHOD, STEP BY STEP

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES, AND ITS LIMIT
Walk-over and drone	Record the sandspit and look for surface artifacts before anything is disturbed
Magnetometer	Detects iron and steel (engine parts, cables, fittings). The Electra's skin and frame are aluminium, which it cannot see, so a "hit" alone proves nothing
Side-scan sonar and sub-bottom profiler	Image the lagoon floor, and send a single beam of sound into the sediment
Hydroprobe	"A little pipe with water forcing through it", to touch the object and find its depth and shape
Water induction dredge	Clears sediment so divers can see the object

The test they set themselves. ALI: "If it is made of aircraft aluminum and has the specific shape and rivet patterns of the Electra, we will know that we have found the remains of Earhart's aircraft." VERIFIED

On the island. After arriving in the dark on 12 Oct, the crew cut a path to the lagoon on the 13th, a trail nicknamed the "Gallagher Highway", and reached the Taraia Peninsula by 1 p.m. The lagoon survey ran on the 14th. Rough seas then made the boat trips unsafe and kept the team on the ship for three days in a row. In all: seven days near the island, four of them ashore. VERIFIED

THE 2026 RESULT

NOT THE PLANE

On 19 October 2026 (local time; the evening of 18 October in the US), Purdue, the Purdue Research Foundation and ALI announced that the expedition had “found no conclusive evidence” that the Electra lay in the lagoon. VERIFIED

QUESTION	WHAT THE TEAM REPORTED	GRADE
What was the object?	The team: “likely a collection of large trees deposited along the peninsula's sandspit.” Its own word is *likely*; so is ours.	VERIFIED
Was it still there?	Mostly not. Much of it had broken apart and washed away; a single Y-shaped piece remained, “a fraction of the anomaly's original size”.	VERIFIED
Why did it look like metal?	A “carbonate veneer”. Other items were coated in a “shiny concretized amalgam of coral sand”.	VERIFIED
Anything recovered?	A steel tube about 30 inches long, found in the lagoon near the Taraia Peninsula, and other items. As of 21 Oct 2026 it had not been identified or linked to the Electra. The finds will be studied for clues to how things drifting in through Tatiman Passage end up on the peninsula.	VERIFIED
What next?	Purdue pledged to continue the search. As of 21 Oct 2026 no new expedition, date or budget had been announced.	VERIFIED

> “The hypothesis has been tested, and the results are in.”
>
> Rick Pettigrew, ALI, expedition leader (Purdue video, Oct 2026)

> “We set out to test a hypothesis, not to guarantee a particular result.” … “She kept flying, and we will keep searching.”
>
> Steve Schultz, Purdue (release, Oct 2026)

The man who called it. Before the team landed, Ric Gillespie, founder of TIGHAR, told Reuters: “It's a tree.” VERIFIED After the result he told Greater Lafayette: “I knew how it was going to turn out.” ATTRIBUTED

What it doesn't settle. One possible resting place was ruled out. The team says it still believes Earhart and Noonan reached Nikumaroro. ATTRIBUTED The official 1937 finding, a crash at sea near Howland, still stands. Neither theory is proven by this result.

MYTH-CHECK

WHERE THE SOURCES DISAGREE

Few stories have been retold as often as this one. Here is what the record says about the claims you'll meet most.

CLAIM YOU'LL SEE	WHAT THE RECORD SAYS	BEST ANSWER
"The bones are a 99% match"	The 2018 study (Jantz, *Forensic Anthropology*) found the 1941 measurements closer to Earhart than to 99% of a 2,776-person reference sample. Its author said "more likely than not"; a critic said it "really doesn't tell us much". The bones themselves are lost.	Suggestive, not proof CONFLICT
"Visible since 1938"	The shape first shows in satellite images in April 2015 (ALI). That it also appears in 1938 aerial photos is ALI's interpretation.	"The team says…" ATTRIBUTED
"The magnetometer found the plane"	A magnetometer sees iron and steel; the Electra was mostly aluminium. No magnetometer or sonar data had been published as of 21 Oct 2026.	Not evidence either way
"It was definitely a tree"	The team's wording is "likely a collection of large trees".	"Probably large trees"
"They found part of the plane"	The steel tube had not been identified or linked to the Electra.	Unidentified
"The trip cost $900,000"	About $900,000 was ALI's anticipated budget. No final cost has been published; the release thanks private donors.	"Budgeted at ~$900K"
"The object is 12–14 m long"	ALI called it "exactly the right size" for the fuselage and tail but published no measurements.	No measured size UNVERIFIED
"The Japanese captured her"	The 2017 "Jaluit dock" photo was in a Japanese travel book published in Oct 1935, two years before the flight.	No credible evidence UNVERIFIED
"The sextant box was Noonan's"	It is now tied to a 1939 US Navy survey of the island.	Not Earhart evidence
"A sonar image found her plane near Howland"	Deep Sea Vision's Jan 2024 image was revisited in Nov 2024: a natural rock formation.	Rock

Smaller drift: the team was 17 (older reports say 16 or 14); the sailing date from Tarawa is given as 6 and 7 Oct; ALI, not Purdue, led the work.

THEORIES AND MONEY

THREE THEORIES, ONE BILL

THEORY	WHO BACKS IT	BEST EVIDENCE OFFERED	BIGGEST PROBLEM
Crash and sink near Howland	The 1937 US finding; Nauticos (David Jourdan) and the late Elgen Long	The 1937 finding that the plane ran out of fuel near Howland; Jourdan says the Coast Guard's data and Nauticos's radio-signal analysis don't support the castaway idea VERIFIED	Sonar searches by Nauticos and others have covered 3,610 sq mi of seabed and found nothing VERIFIED
Castaway on Nikumaroro	TIGHAR since 1989; the 2026 team	Post-loss radio calls (TIGHAR rates 57 of 120 credible, its own rating); the 1940 bones; the Bevington photo; 1930s artifacts ATTRIBUTED	No confirmed Electra part has ever been recovered from the island; the bones are lost VERIFIED
Japanese capture	A 2017 History Channel documentary	A photo said to show her on a dock	The photo was published in 1935 VERIFIED

We grade the evidence and the problems, not the theories. None of the three is proven.

WHO PAID TO LOOK

The 2026 bill. ALI anticipated about $900,000 for this phase. ATTRIBUTED The Purdue Research Foundation gave a $500,000 line of credit; its repayment terms are not published. VERIFIED At one point ALI listed pledges of about half the budget (undated page). ATTRIBUTED The release thanks private donors; no final cost has been published. ATTRIBUTED

The 1936 plane. Purdue says about $40,000 from its Earhart fund went on the Electra. ATTRIBUTED That is about $0.93 million in 2025 dollars (US CPI-U, 1936 = 13.9, 2025 = 321.9). OUR CALCULATION Roughly what the 2026 trip was budgeted at.

Whose plane would it be? Any wreck on Nikumaroro lies in Kiribati's territory, and removing anything needs Kiribati's approval. VERIFIED No one has put a dollar value on the Electra, and we won't either.

ALI had offered donors of $25,000 or more a berth on a larger ship for a 2027 dig, a phase that depended on a positive identification. VERIFIED This page explains who paid; it is not financial advice.

OPEN CASE

WHAT TO WATCH NEXT

The lagoon is ruled out, but Earhart's plane is still missing. These are the checkable things that will move the story, as of 21 Oct 2026.

WHAT	WHAT TO LOOK FOR	WHERE IT WILL APPEAR
The steel tube	Whether the 30-inch tube and the other finds are identified, and what they say about how debris drifts into the lagoon. Not identified as of 21 Oct 2026.	Purdue newsroom; amelia.prf.org
The survey data	The magnetometer, sonar and sediment results had not been published when we checked.	Purdue; ALI's Taraia page
A next search	Purdue has pledged to keep searching. Watch for a place, a date or a budget; none had been announced.	Purdue newsroom
The recovered items	The release did not say where the tube and other items will go, or what Kiribati has agreed.	Purdue; Government of Kiribati
The other camps	TIGHAR still argues the plane broke up off the reef; crash-and-sink teams still argue for the seabed near Howland.	tighar.org; expedition announcements

STILL UNEXPLAINED, WHATEVER THE LAGOON HELD

- [ ] The 1940 bones: later lost, so only a doctor's 1941 measurements remain.
- [ ] The post-loss radio calls, and the direction-finder bearings that seemed to cross near Nikumaroro.
- [ ] The object in Bevington's October 1937 reef photo.
- [ ] TIGHAR's 1930s artifacts from the Seven Site, none tied directly to Earhart.
- [ ] The wreck itself: Howland seabed, or the reef slope off Nikumaroro.

Case updates. This is a live case. When something on this list moves, we re-issue this file with a new “checked to” date, and subscribers hear about it first.

SOURCES

CHECK OUR WORK

Primary records first (Purdue, ALI, the National Archives), then named news reports. Quoted words are short extracts for reference and comment, attributed to their source. Gillespie's post-result words come from one outlet. Facts checked to 21 Oct 2026; anything that can change is dated.

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12. **CBS News, 14 Oct 2026.** https://www.cbsnews.com/news/amelia-earhart-plane-search-nikumaroro-expedition/
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16. **Purdue Libraries Archives blog, 13 Mar 2017 (the 1936 fund); Indianapolis Star via Yahoo (the $40,000).** https://blogs.lib.purdue.edu/asc/2017/03/13/remembering-amelia-earharts-round-the-world-flight-the-80th-anniversary-of-her-shining-adventure-part-1-of-2 · https://www.yahoo.com/news/purdue-helped-buy-plane-amelia-145119390.html
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How this file was made. A fact desk read the releases, videos and reports, graded every claim, and kept a do-not-say list (no "99% match", no "plane found", no object size). Spotted an error? Reply to the email this file came with, or write to hello@vibewithjudeo.com, and we'll correct it and credit you.

Independence. Vibe with Judeo is an independent documentary channel, not affiliated with Purdue, the Purdue Research Foundation, ALI, TIGHAR or the Government of Kiribati. No images of human remains appear in this file.

THAT WAS THE FREE EDITION

MORE CASE FILES

One case file for each new Vibe with Judeo documentary: the timeline, the map, the myth-check and every source, graded so you can check our work.

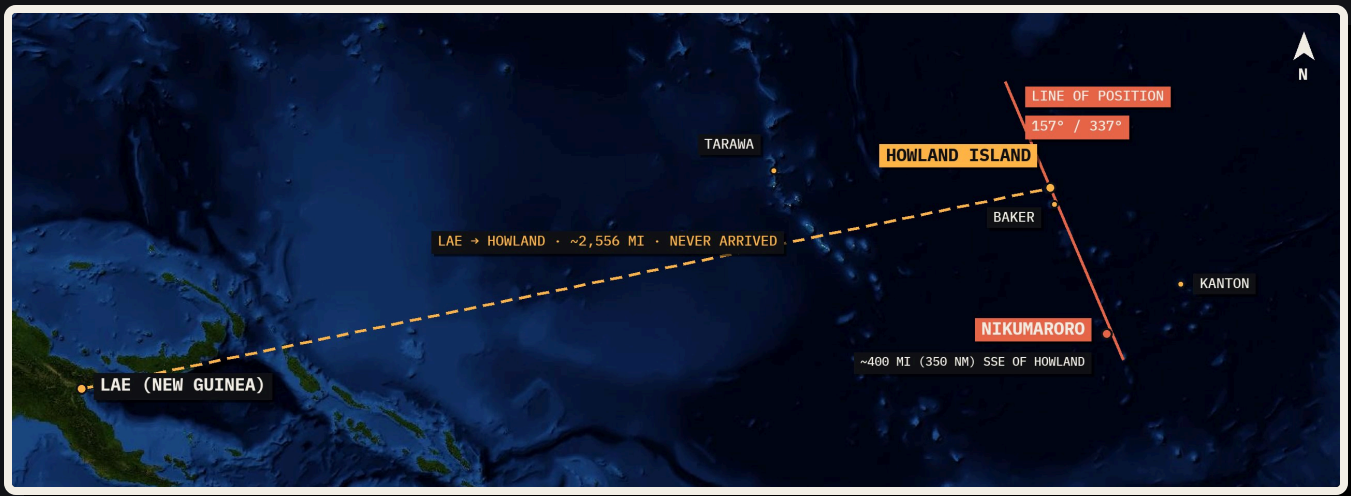
WATCH THE STORY

- ☐ Part 2, the result: **youtu.be/mvHC5WpvgQc**
- ☐ Part 1, the case for the lagoon: **youtu.be/AC0mXDZ7iZs**

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This is a live case. If the steel tube is identified, the survey data is published or a new search is announced, we'll re-issue this file with a new date.



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